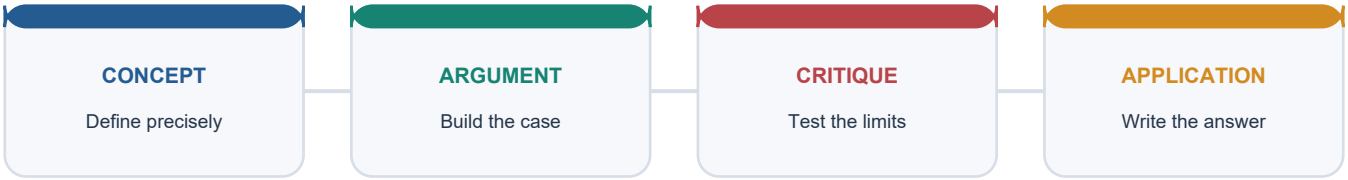
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Sher Shah Sur & the Sur Empire - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Sher Shah Sur & the Sur Empire - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Part I - 32 workbook MCQs with full option-wise explanations

Workbook MCQ 1

Question: The safest description of Farid's early political formation is that he:

- A. gained administrative exposure in his father's jagirs and parganas before rising in Bihar politics.
- B. was born as the hereditary emperor of a settled Sur state.
- C. entered India only after the Second Battle of Panipat.
- D. was appointed Akbar's governor of Bengal.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. The canonical files make Sasaram experience and Bihar service central because Sher Shah first learnt cultivation, intermediaries and assignments at that level.
- **B.** Incorrect. Farid began as a rising Afghan notable, not as the pre-born emperor of an already consolidated empire.
- **C.** Incorrect. The Second Battle of Panipat belongs to 1556, long after Farid had become Sher Shah and long after his death.
- **D.** Incorrect. Akbar belongs to the next topic's world, whereas Farid's ascent unfolded inside Bihar-Bengal politics before Mughal restoration.

Examiner trap: legend or late-Mughal chronology substituted for early eastern career

Workbook MCQ 2

Question: Surajgarh is most useful in Topic 14 because it marks:

- A. Humayun's restoration to Delhi in 1555.
- B. the scaling-up of Sher Khan's Bihar-centred power against Bengal in 1534.
- C. the permanent annexation of Kashmir by Sher Shah.
- D. Akbar's introduction of dahsala.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Humayun's restoration came two decades later and belongs to the end of the Sur phase rather than to Sher Khan's rise.
- **B.** Correct. Surajgarh raised Sher Khan from a strong regional player to a contender with larger eastern prestige, resources and bargaining power.
- **C.** Incorrect. Kashmir is explicitly excluded from the broad Sur-empire formulation in the canonical owner.
- **D.** Incorrect. Dahsala is a later Akbarian revenue development, not a feature of Sher Khan's pre-1540 ascent.

Examiner trap: Surajgarh treated as a decorative date instead of the Bihar-Bengal scale-up

Workbook MCQ 3

Question: Why are Chausa and Kannauj retained inside Topic 14 at all?

- A. They prove that Sher Shah invented gunpowder artillery.
- B. They make Humayun's Bengal crisis unnecessary to understand.
- C. They form the bounded bridge by which Sher Khan's eastern rise became Sher Shah's sovereignty.
- D. They belong wholly to Akbar's reign.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The battles matter here for sovereignty transfer, not as proof that one ruler created gunpowder warfare from scratch.
- **B.** Incorrect. Topic 13 still owns the full eastern-campaign and battle narrative; Topic 14 keeps only the threshold function.
- **C.** Correct. These victories convert regional Afghan scale into imperial authority, which is exactly why Topic 14 begins from their institutional consequence.
- **D.** Incorrect. Akbar enters later; Chausa and Kannauj sit in the Humayun-Sher Khan struggle of 1539-1540.

Examiner trap: battle names memorised without topic-boundary discipline

Workbook MCQ 4

Question: A map of the Sur empire should explicitly qualify that:

- A. only Bihar and Bengal were ruled.
- B. Kashmir was the Sur capital zone.
- C. the empire formed an exact modern provincial rectangle.
- D. Kashmir was excluded even though the realm broadly ran from Bengal to the Indus with uneven western and frontier control.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The Sur sphere stretched far beyond Bihar and Bengal into the Ganga core, the north-west and western campaign fields.
- **B.** Incorrect. The canonical wording does the opposite: it marks Kashmir as outside the broad imperial extent.
- **C.** Incorrect. Medieval conquest space cannot be represented safely as a neat modern province map with uniform density.
- **D.** Correct. This option keeps both halves of the truth together: the empire was large, yet its control varied and Kashmir stood outside it.

Examiner trap: scale remembered but qualification forgotten

Workbook MCQ 5

Question: Afghan kingship under Sher Shah is best described as:

- A. a strong personal monarchy working through chiefs, service elites and assignments.
- B. an elected tribal republic with no rulerly hierarchy.
- C. a purely Turkish court copied unchanged from Balban's age.
- D. a system that functioned without revenue officers or scribes.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. The Sur polity centred on a forceful king, yet it still depended on Afghan nobles, service expectations and administrative linkage.
- **B.** Incorrect. Afghan political weight did not amount to elective republican government; a monarch clearly stood at the apex.
- **C.** Incorrect. The advanced owner explicitly resists flattening the Sur regime into a simple replay of an earlier Turkish court model.
- **D.** Incorrect. Finance, chancery and record functions remained crucial to the very state capacity Sher Shah is known for.

Examiner trap: Afghan identity converted into either tribal-romantic equality or total statelessness

Workbook MCQ 6

Question: Which formulation of territorial administration is historically safer?

- A. Sher Shah divided the empire into Akbar's finished suba map in 1540.
- B. Sarkar or shiq and pargana remained operative units, and Akbar's later provincial vocabulary should not be projected backward carelessly.
- C. Each village was ruled directly from Delhi without intermediary layers.
- D. Pargana was another word for the whole empire.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The suba framework belongs to a later Mughal order and should not be retrofitted onto Sur administration.
- **B.** Correct. This keeps the scale and terminology disciplined: sarkar or shiq above pargana, with later Mughal provincial development kept separate.
- **C.** Incorrect. Topic 14 repeatedly emphasises mediation through officers, headmen, zamindars and record-holders rather than direct one-step court rule.
- **D.** Incorrect. Pargana is a sub-territorial unit, not a synonym for the empire itself.

Examiner trap: Akbarian administrative familiarity imposed on Sher Shah's world

Workbook MCQ 7

Question: The Sur revenue chain begins most accurately with:

- A. a ten-year cash average imposed before land was known.
- B. confiscation of all village land and redistribution to cavalrymen.
- C. measurement of sown land followed by classification and rai-based assessment.
- D. payment only in foreign silver.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. A fixed ten-year cash average belongs to later Mughal revenue discussion, not to the Sur chain described in the canonical owners.
- **B.** Incorrect. The revenue issue here is specification of demand, not wholesale confiscation of every village holding.
- **C.** Correct. Measurement, classification and rai form the working sequence that makes patta and qabuliyat intelligible.
- **D.** Incorrect. Revenue could move through cash or kind; foreign silver is not the starting mechanism of the system.

Examiner trap: later zabt memories substituted for the Sur assessment sequence

Workbook MCQ 8

Question: The patta-qabuliyat pair is best understood as:

- A. permanent abolition of zamindars.
- B. British ryotwari before British rule.
- C. an informal oral pledge unrelated to records.
- D. written assessment plus cultivator acceptance inside a still-mediated agrarian order.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Zamindars remained part of rural control and collection; written assessment did not erase them from the countryside.
- **B.** Incorrect. Ryotwari is a colonial category and misdescribes a sixteenth-century system still dependent on intermediaries and local officers.
- **C.** Incorrect. The importance of patta-qabuliyat lies precisely in recordable demand and acknowledged liability, not in pure informality.

- **D.** Correct. This pairing captures the Sur attempt to make revenue legible without turning the system into direct modern peasant-state contact.

Examiner trap: documentation mistaken for direct agrarian modernity

Workbook MCQ 9

Question: How should the famous one-third state share be written in a secure answer?

- A. as a commonly stated norm in core descriptions, not as proof of identical collection everywhere
- B. as an exact annual legal rate for every crop and district without exception
- C. as the label for Multan alone
- D. as a ration scale for the standing army

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. This is the safest phrasing because it preserves the remembered norm while leaving room for regional variation and practical mediation.
- **B.** Incorrect. The sources do not justify a spreadsheet-like claim of universal identical collection in every district and every year.
- **C.** Incorrect. Multan appears as an exception warning, not as the sole place where the one-third idea existed.
- **D.** Incorrect. The one-third figure belongs to agrarian assessment discourse, not to military provisioning terminology.

Examiner trap: neat ratio mistaken for empire-wide mechanical uniformity

Workbook MCQ 10

Question: The silver rupee claim is safest when it says:

- A. Sher Shah coined the first money ever seen in India.
- B. Sher Shah standardised a durable silver denomination even though earlier silver currencies already existed.
- C. coinage lost significance after his death.
- D. the Sur monetary system mattered only inside Rajasthan.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Money and silver coinage pre-dated Sher Shah by centuries; the claim of first-ever creation is historically unsound.
- **B.** Correct. His major monetary importance lies in standardisation of weight and fineness, not in inventing silver currency from nothing.
- **C.** Incorrect. The very point of calling the rupee important is its later durability, not its disappearance after 1545.
- **D.** Incorrect. The monetary significance of the Sur standard far exceeded one western region.

Examiner trap: standardisation inflated into invention mythology

Workbook MCQ 11

Question: Customs simplification under Sher Shah is best described as:

- A. abolition of every levy in the empire.
- B. a fully modern GST schedule with nationally fixed rates.
- C. concentration of duties at controlled entry or sale points instead of tolerating many arbitrary transit levies.
- D. a policy confined to the Portuguese coast.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The reform concerned rationalising collection, not dissolving the fiscal claims of the state altogether.

- **B.** Incorrect. Importing GST-like modern uniformity creates a false administrative precision unsupported by the sources.
- **C.** Correct. This wording captures the commercial logic: fewer petty interruptions, more legible dues, and easier long-distance movement.
- **D.** Incorrect. The customs issue in Topic 14 belongs to inland imperial circulation, not to a coastal Portuguese-only frame.

Examiner trap: simplified dues turned into tax abolition or modern tariff uniformity

Workbook MCQ 12

Question: Which road statement is most accurate?

- A. Sher Shah invented overland communication in northern India.
- B. The famous route served only the Delhi-Agra court zone.
- C. No older imperial corridor existed before Sher Shah.
- D. He repaired and extended older corridors later grouped under the Grand Trunk Road label.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Long-distance routes existed earlier; Sher Shah's fame comes from repair, extension and policing rather than absolute invention.
- **B.** Incorrect. The core corridor is remembered on a much wider east-west scale, not as a small ceremonial avenue.
- **C.** Incorrect. Denying earlier route history is exactly the exaggeration the canonical sources warn against.
- **D.** Correct. This formulation keeps both achievement and historical continuity visible.

Examiner trap: route history collapsed into the slogan 'Sher Shah built the GT Road'

Workbook MCQ 13

Question: Sarais are analytically important because they were:

- A. lodging, market, security and relay nodes that linked commerce with administration.
- B. private palaces for nobles with no public function.
- C. modern railway stations in premodern dress.
- D. only religious shelters unrelated to state communication.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. A sarai concentrated travellers, goods, official oversight and message movement, which is why it belongs to governance history.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sarais served wayfarers and routes; they were not merely aristocratic residences detached from circulation.
- **C.** Incorrect. The comparison to railway stations can help memory loosely, but it becomes misleading if treated as literal historical equivalence.
- **D.** Incorrect. Their role in trade, security and dak work prevents them from being reduced to devotional hospitality alone.

Examiner trap: sarai remembered as kindness but not as an information-and-control node

Workbook MCQ 14

Question: Why should the two-karoh interval be handled cautiously?

- A. It proves a modern total-road measurement in kilometres.
- B. It is a historical spacing expression that should not be converted into fake modern precision.
- C. It names a cavalry rank.
- D. It refers to the price of one silver coin.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. A local interval tradition does not justify exact modern survey claims for the full road network.
- **B.** Correct. Retaining the historical unit respects what the source actually offers while resisting false mathematical certainty.
- **C.** Incorrect. Two karohs concerns route spacing, not military hierarchy.
- **D.** Incorrect. The phrase belongs to roads and sarais, not to coin pricing.

Examiner trap: historical measure overtranslated into bogus modern exactness

Workbook MCQ 15

Question: Which statement traces dagh and chehra most safely?

- A. They were created in finished form by Aurangzeb.
- B. They were customs labels for road checkpoints.
- C. Sultanate precedents existed; Sher Shah adapted or revived them for control, and Akbar later used related verification in a different imperial framework.
- D. They were the names of two Sur forts.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Moving these devices to the late Mughal period erases both Sultanate precedent and Sur relevance.
- **B.** Incorrect. Dagh and chehra belong to military verification, not to customs collection.
- **C.** Correct. This sequence preserves continuity without confusing Sher Shah's use with Akbar's later mansabdari setting.
- **D.** Incorrect. Neither term names a fort; both refer to identification and inspection practices.

Examiner trap: provenance of army-control devices muddled across dynasties and functions

Workbook MCQ 16

Question: The Rohtas distinction matters because:

- A. Rohtas and Rohtasgarh are exactly the same frontier fort.
- B. Rohtas lay beside Sher Shah's tomb at Sasaram.
- C. Rohtas served only Bengal delta policing.
- D. north-western Rohtas guarded the Gakhhar-Mughal-return frontier, whereas Rohtasgarh belonged to the Bihar zone.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Similar names create a trap, but the two forts occupy different geographies and different strategic settings.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sasaram is linked with Sher Shah's tomb, not with locating Rohtas beside it.
- **C.** Incorrect. Rohtas in this context belongs to the north-west frontier logic, not to delta policing in Bengal.
- **D.** Correct. The contrast between frontier Rohtas and Bihar Rohtasgarh is precisely the memory safeguard UPSC may test.

Examiner trap: similar-sounding forts merged into one imagined site

Workbook MCQ 17

Question: Sher Shah's justice reputation is most securely linked to:

- A. safer roads backed by local responsibility and stern punishment.
- B. proof that no theft ever occurred in any district.
- C. qazi decisions operating without coercive authority.

- D. abolition of zamindars from the countryside.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Merchants and travellers remembered route safety because the regime combined official justice with pressure on local communities and power-holders.
- **B.** Incorrect. Chronicle praise of security cannot be treated as a complete statistical record of zero crime.
- **C.** Incorrect. Judicial authority in Topic 14 worked alongside punishment, patrols and other coercive supports rather than in their absence.
- **D.** Incorrect. Zamindars were controlled and used; they did not disappear from the countryside.

Examiner trap: ruler-ideal justice anecdote mistaken for exact crime-free reality

Workbook MCQ 18

Question: What is the safest statement about zamindars under Sher Shah?

- A. They vanished once patta-qabuliyat appeared.
- B. They were controlled, punished or used as local intermediaries rather than abolished.
- C. They became identical to British district collectors.
- D. They handled only ritual matters and no revenue or rural power.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Written assessment changed the fiscal framework but did not erase landed local authority from village society.
- **B.** Correct. This captures the Sur state's practical approach: discipline where necessary, use where useful, and never assume disappearance.
- **C.** Incorrect. British district collectors belong to a very different bureaucratic world and cannot stand in for sixteenth-century zamindars.
- **D.** Incorrect. Zamindars mattered precisely because they were embedded in rural power, collection and local influence.

Examiner trap: intermediary control misread as intermediary abolition

Workbook MCQ 19

Question: The Raisen-Puran Mal episode is best handled as:

- A. final proof of one empire-wide religious policy in every district.
- B. a routine revenue settlement with no legitimacy issue.
- C. a controversy over surrender, coercion and political trust that must be discussed with site-specific caution.
- D. an episode too uncertain to mention at all.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. One violent and disputed episode cannot safely bear the weight of a total theory about every Sur religious action.
- **B.** Incorrect. The issue is precisely that surrender and violence turned the event into a legitimacy problem, not a routine tax note.
- **C.** Correct. This wording keeps politics, coercion and trust together while refusing both apologetic flattening and sweeping communal generalisation.
- **D.** Incorrect. The episode is usable when bounded carefully; silence would throw away important evidence about legitimacy and violence.

Examiner trap: a single controversial siege either universalised or erased

Workbook MCQ 20

Question: Why does Kalinjar occupy a major place in Topic 14?

- A. It was the place where Humayun recovered Delhi in 1555.
- B. It was Sher Shah's coronation venue.
- C. It created permanent peace in Bundelkhand.
- D. Sher Shah died there in 1545 during a siege marked by a gunpowder accident.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Humayun's restoration belongs to the end of the Sur phase and is not a Kalinjar event.
- **B.** Incorrect. Kalinjar is remembered in this topic for Sher Shah's death, not for his enthronement.
- **C.** Incorrect. The siege underscores military risk and succession shock, not a final Bundelkhand settlement that removed all future tension.
- **D.** Correct. Kalinjar matters because the king's death there in 1545 exposed how much the Sur system depended on personal leadership.

Examiner trap: Kalinjar treated as just another fort instead of the succession-turning siege

Workbook MCQ 21

Question: Islam Shah's reign is best described as:

- A. a continuation of Sur structures with sharper royal discipline over nobles and camps.
- B. an irrelevant pause with no administrative value.
- C. an immediate surrender of Delhi to Humayun.
- D. the abolition of monarchy in favour of confederate rule.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. Islam Shah matters because he continued the Sur framework and intensified monarchical control, proving that the state did not vanish in 1545.
- **B.** Incorrect. Treating him as a blank pause hides the crucial evidence of continuity between Sher Shah and later fragmentation.
- **C.** Incorrect. Humayun's restoration came only after later Sur divisions had deepened.
- **D.** Incorrect. His reign moved toward stronger monarchy, not away from it.

Examiner trap: Islam Shah erased from the storyline between achievement and collapse

Workbook MCQ 22

Question: The rapid Sur collapse after 1553 is best linked to:

- A. one isolated battlefield setback alone.
- B. violent succession, rival claimants, factional armies and fragile elite cohesion after Islam Shah.
- C. the disappearance of all Afghan elites from north India overnight.
- D. Akbar's mansabdari system already functioning against them.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. No single battle explains the multiplication of claimants and the political fragmentation after Islam Shah's death.
- **B.** Correct. Firuz's killing, the rise of Adil, Sikandar and Ibrahim, and fractured military followings together explain the collapse far better than a one-cause story.
- **C.** Incorrect. Afghan political actors remained very present; the problem was division, not disappearance.
- **D.** Incorrect. Mansabdari belongs to Akbar's later imperial order and cannot explain the Sur breakdown of 1553-55.

Examiner trap: complicated succession crisis compressed into a single-cause fall narrative

Workbook MCQ 23

Question: Hemu enters Topic 14 mainly as:

- A. Sher Shah's son and direct heir.
- B. the architect of Rohtas fort under Sher Shah.
- C. Adil Shah's leading military-administrative figure during late Sur fragmentation.
- D. the author of *Tarikh-i Sher Shahi*.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Hemu was not Sher Shah's son; he rose in the later Sur political field under Adil Shah.
- **B.** Incorrect. Rohtas is associated with frontier strategy, not with Hemu's architectural authorship.
- **C.** Correct. His significance here lies in late-Sur power politics, showing how military-administrative talent operated amid dynastic disunity.
- **D.** Incorrect. *Tarikh-i Sher Shahi* is associated with Abbas Khan Sarwani, not with Hemu.

Examiner trap: late-Sur actors confused with Sher Shah's own household lineage

Workbook MCQ 24

Question: Sher Shah's tomb at Sasaram is best used in an answer as:

- A. evidence for the battlefield deployment at Chausa.
- B. a British-period memorial unrelated to Sur kingship.
- C. proof that every reform reached every district perfectly.
- D. monumental evidence of royal legitimacy and memory across Sher Shah and Islam Shah phases.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. A mausoleum can illuminate royal memory and architecture, but it cannot reconstruct a battle line at Chausa.
- **B.** Incorrect. Sasaram is a sixteenth-century Sur monument, not a colonial memorial detached from that context.
- **C.** Incorrect. Monumental grandeur does not certify universal administrative success across the whole empire.
- **D.** Correct. The tomb is historically valuable as evidence of sovereign self-fashioning, scale, patronage and continuity across two reign phases.

Examiner trap: monument treated either as mere tourism or as proof of every other institutional claim

Workbook MCQ 25

Question: Purana Qila and Qila-i-Kuhna should be handled as:

- A. a multi-phase Humayun-Sur-Mughal urban-fort landscape rather than a one-line single-patron attribution.
- B. irrelevant to Topic 14 because they lie outside India.
- C. exclusively post-Aurangzeb structures.
- D. Bengal sarais later turned into forts.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. These Delhi structures belong to a layered political landscape in which Humayun, Sur intervention and later Mughal occupation overlap.
- **B.** Incorrect. They matter precisely because they place Sur legitimacy inside the Delhi imperial setting.
- **C.** Incorrect. Their relevance here is sixteenth-century, not a late-Mughal afterthought.
- **D.** Incorrect. Neither structure is a Bengal sarai; both belong to the Delhi fort-mosque environment.

Examiner trap: complex Delhi monument history flattened into one label

Workbook MCQ 26

Question: What is the best commercial inference from Sher Shah's reforms?

- A. Roads mattered only for moving soldiers.
- B. Standard coinage, safer routes and simplified dues lowered some transaction costs while also extending state surveillance.
- C. Merchants paid no dues anywhere after 1540.
- D. North Indian trade became fully modern in the capitalist sense.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Military movement mattered, but merchants, tax collectors and news carriers used the same infrastructure.
- **B.** Correct. This option preserves the double edge of reform: easier circulation for trade and stronger oversight for the state.
- **C.** Incorrect. Customs simplification did not amount to the disappearance of dues or state fiscal claims.
- **D.** Incorrect. The reforms were important without turning sixteenth-century exchange into a modern capitalist market order.

Examiner trap: commercial benefit narrated without the parallel surveillance and extraction logic

Workbook MCQ 27

Question: Which sentence best captures the peasant-side limit of Sur revenue reform?

- A. Patta guaranteed equal bargaining power between state and cultivator.
- B. Measurement ended climate risk and crop variation.
- C. Written assessment could clarify demand but did not remove coercion, cesses or intermediary pressure.
- D. Every cultivator paid only in cash.

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. A written record may reduce some arbitrariness, yet it does not place peasant and state on socially equal footing.
- **B.** Incorrect. Climatic risk and crop uncertainty remained built into agrarian life regardless of administrative neatness.
- **C.** Correct. This is the balanced formulation: clearer demand in principle, continued pressure and mediation in practice.
- **D.** Incorrect. Collection could take cash or kind, and cash access was uneven across regions and cultivators.

Examiner trap: record-keeping translated into peasant security that the evidence cannot support

Workbook MCQ 28

Question: Which statement best describes Sher Shah's relation to Akbar?

- A. Akbar copied every Sur institution unchanged.
- B. Sur experience had no later relevance.
- C. Sher Shah created the mansabdari system in final Mughal form.
- D. Akbar adapted selected Sur precedents at a larger scale under a different ruling class and documentary regime.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Later Mughal development involved selection and modification, not mechanical copying.
- **B.** Incorrect. The continuity in revenue logic, military verification, roads and coinage is too substantial to deny altogether.

- **C.** Incorrect. Mansabdari in its Mughal sense belongs later and cannot be back-written as a completed Sur institution.
- **D.** Correct. This option preserves both influence and difference, which is the safest historiographical balance.

Examiner trap: legacy reduced either to copy-paste borrowing or to total discontinuity

Workbook MCQ 29

Question: Which historiographical verdict is the most secure?

- A. Sher Shah was an effective short-reign systematiser, not an isolated genius outside historical process.
- B. Later historians should be ignored completely because all chronicles are useless.
- C. Sarwani's admiration proves perfect objectivity.
- D. Administrative success absolves every coercive act automatically.

Correct answer: A

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Correct. The advanced owner explicitly joins admiration for Sher Shah's effectiveness with resistance to the lone-genius myth.
- **B.** Incorrect. Chronological and administrative insight would be lost if chronicles were discarded wholesale rather than read critically.
- **C.** Incorrect. Admiration is exactly why Sarwani requires careful qualification, not uncritical acceptance.
- **D.** Incorrect. Administrative accomplishment and moral evaluation of coercive episodes must be analysed separately.

Examiner trap: praise or scepticism pushed so far that historical method disappears

Workbook MCQ 30

Question: Why does the Multan caution matter in Topic 14?

- A. It proves that Sur revenue reform never operated in the core regions.
- B. It reminds us that the neat measured system had regional exceptions and could not be described as mechanically uniform.
- C. It makes Multan the Sur capital.
- D. It shows that patta and rai were borrowed Portuguese words.

Correct answer: B

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. An exception warning does not cancel the relevance of revenue reform in the core zones where the system is most strongly described.
- **B.** Correct. Multan works as a historical brake on overconfident uniformity claims about measurement, rate and collection.
- **C.** Incorrect. The caution concerns revenue reach, not a change in imperial capital.
- **D.** Incorrect. Patta and rai belong to agrarian-administrative vocabulary, not to a Portuguese lexical borrowing story.

Examiner trap: exception note ignored when making universal administrative claims

Workbook MCQ 31

Question: Which source most directly anchors the claim of Sur monetary standardisation?

- A. later tourism brochures alone
- B. heroic legends about Farid
- C. surviving coins that preserve metal, mint, legend and standard information
- D. only Akbar's court regulations

Correct answer: C

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. Tourism writing may help with public memory, but it cannot replace primary numismatic evidence for monetary standards.
- **B.** Incorrect. Heroic narrative about the ruler's life tells us nothing secure about mint practice or coin metal.
- **C.** Correct. Coins are primary evidence precisely because they retain material and inscriptional data relevant to standardisation.
- **D.** Incorrect. Akbar's regulations may show later adaptation, but they cannot by themselves prove Sher Shah's own mint standard.

Examiner trap: numismatic claim built on memory sources instead of coins themselves

Workbook MCQ 32

Question: Which overall assessment of Sher Shah is the most defensible?

- A. Sur rule is merely a blank footnote between Humayun and Akbar.
- B. Sher Shah's state was fully modern in the twentieth-century sense.
- C. The short reign makes achievement unknowable and therefore irrelevant.
- D. Sur rule linked conquest to administration, circulation and coercion impressively, but source idealisation and rapid fragmentation require a qualified verdict.

Correct answer: D

Option-wise explanations:

- **A.** Incorrect. The Sur state is too consequential in revenue, roads, coinage and military-administrative history to be treated as an empty interval.
- **B.** Incorrect. The regime was effective without becoming a modern impersonal bureaucratic nation-state.
- **C.** Incorrect. Short duration creates evidentiary caution, not historical insignificance.
- **D.** Correct. This is the examiner-grade balance: real state-building achievement, checked by source limits, uneven reach and succession fragility.

Examiner trap: final verdict pushed toward either dismissal or anachronistic glorification

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Direct PYQ ownership audit

The canonical Basic and Advanced Topic 14 owners were rechecked first. They route **zero direct UPSC Civil Services PYQs to Topic 14 for 2018-2026**. The 2026 local official-paper and ledger search was repeated across `books\mains\2026\`, `knowledge-export\Mains PYQ\`, `exams\papers\`, `new_papers\`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-GS1-2026.md`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-GS1-GS3-Static-2026.md`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\PYQ-INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2026.md` and `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\PYQ-MAINS-COVERAGE-AUDIT-2026.md`; no Topic 14-owned 2026 prelims or mains item on Sher Shah, the Sur empire, revenue, roads, currency or army control was verified locally.

Transparent routed / adjacent support items

All four support items below are retained openly as **adjacent or routed PYQs**, not relabelled direct Topic 14 ownership. They sharpen administrative scale, agrarian distinction, source method and technology-state capacity reasoning relevant to Sher Shah's reign.

Adjacent PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 administrative-scale route (wording verified locally; key inferred)

Question as securely verified from local OCR: With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?

- A. Paragana-Sarkar-Suba
- B. Sarkar-Paragana-Suba

- C. Suba-Sarkar-Paragana
- D. Paragana-Suba-Sarkar

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: A. Paragana-Sarkar-Suba. Confidence: high.

How to think it through: Begin from the smallest routine territorial unit here, the pargana. A sarkar or shiq grouped larger administrative space above it. Suba belongs to the larger Mughal provincial framework above the sarkar. This is adjacent to Topic 14 because Sher Shah's own vocabulary stops safely at sarkar-pargana scale; the question warns against projecting Akbarian familiarity backward without ordering the units properly.

Demand decoding: This is a scale-order elimination question, not a request for a full Sur constitutional essay. Use it to keep the territorial ladder clear and to prevent suba language from casually replacing Topic 14's safer sarkar-pargana formulation.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Mark pargana as the lowest unit first, hold suba for the widest unit, and eliminate every option that disrupts those two anchors before choosing the only surviving sequence.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: The route earns marks because it trains precise territorial ordering while remaining honest that the ledger routes the item generally through medieval-Mughal administration rather than directly to Sher Shah.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one short line that Sher Shah's own administration should still be written primarily through sarkars or shiqs and parganas, so the correct ordering does not tempt you into careless backward projection.

Adjacent PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2019 agrarian-intermediary route (wording verified locally; key inferred)

Question as securely verified from local OCR: With reference to Mughal India, what is/are the difference/differences between Jagirdar and Zamindar?

1. Jagirdars were holders of land assignments in lieu of judicial and police duties, whereas Zamindars were holders of revenue rights without obligation to perform any duty other than revenue collection.
2. Land assignments to Jagirdars were hereditary and revenue rights of Zamindars were not hereditary.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 only
- C. Both 1 and 2
- D. Neither 1 nor 2

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: D. Neither 1 nor 2. Confidence: high.

How to think it through: Statement 1 fails because jagirdars are not defined by judicial-police duty in that way, and zamindars cannot be reduced to revenue-right holders with no wider local role. Statement 2 also fails because jagirs were not hereditary offices in the sense stated, while zamindari claims often had hereditary character. In Topic 14 this adjacent item is useful because Sher Shah's countryside still depended on intermediaries and service assignments; one cannot flatten all rural authority into a single category.

Demand decoding: Treat this as a distinction question about agrarian power-holders. The relevant Topic 14 lesson is not Mughal institutional history in full, but the need to separate assignment-holding service elites from locally rooted intermediaries.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Test each statement separately; once Statement 1 collapses on function and Statement 2 collapses on heredity, the code row resolves to the final option without guesswork.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks by protecting a crucial conceptual boundary. Sher Shah's use of zamindars and officers becomes clearer when students stop treating every holder of rights in the countryside as the same figure.

How to improve/strengthen: After eliminating the statements, add one sentence explaining that Topic 14's revenue collection still moved through local power and record networks rather than through an abstract peasant-state channel.

Routed PYQ 3 - UPSC GS-I 2020 source-method support

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Persian literary sources are indispensable for Topic 14 because they preserve the political vocabulary, administrative self-image and moral world in which Sher Shah was remembered. Abbas Khan Sarwani's *Tarikh-i Sher Shahi* is central: it gives the richest account of roads, sarais, justice, revenue, campaigns and rulerly conduct. Yet its value lies precisely in being read with caution. It was written later under Akbar and admires Sher Shah, so it often presents the regime in a polished and ideal form. Nizamuddin Ahmad's *Tabaqat-i Akbari* helps with chronology and dynastic synthesis, while Mughal retrospective writing reveals how the Sur interlude was later judged from within a restored Mughal order.

These texts therefore reflect the age by showing elite assumptions about kingship, order, religion, conquest and administration. They do not function as neutral departmental files. Coins, inscriptions, forts, the Sasaram tomb and the Purana Qila landscape are necessary checks because they can verify titles, mints, dated constructions and political claims. The best comment is that Persian literary sources reveal the spirit of the age most effectively when they are treated as historically rich but interested witnesses.

Demand decoding: This is a comment on source value and limitation together. In Topic 14, the answer must move beyond praise of chronicles and show how Sarwani, Nizamuddin and material evidence speak to one another.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Open with a two-part thesis on value and caution, use Sarwani and Nizamuddin as named textual anchors, and then end by stating what coins, inscriptions and monuments can verify more securely than literary admiration can.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: The route earns marks because it converts a broad medieval-source demand into a precise Sur source-method answer without pretending that literary texts are transparent administrative ledgers.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one compact example of what coin evidence can prove - such as metal, mint or legend - so the non-literary corroboration point becomes even sharper.

Routed PYQ 4 - UPSC GS-I 2023 technology-state-capacity route

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: The Sultanate period saw important technological and technical diffusion in architecture, irrigation, textile production, warfare and administrative communication. The pointed arch, dome and broader lime-mortar building practice changed the scale and finish of construction. Devices such as the spinning wheel and the Persian wheel affected craft productivity and irrigation. In war and transport, improved cavalry equipment, stronger fortification practice and expanding communication routes mattered increasingly to state power.

The social influence of these changes lay in altered labour demand, urban growth, state reach and agrarian extraction. Better irrigation could support cultivation; textile techniques affected artisans and markets; new building methods reshaped urban landscapes and patronage; military and route technologies strengthened the ability of rulers to move troops, protect roads and demand revenue. Topic 14 borrows this routed question only for the later Sur extension of that logic. Sher Shah's roads, sarais, forts, military verification and circulation system show how technological or technical change mattered most when joined to organisation. The safest conclusion is that technology changed society through state capacity and production networks, not through hardware alone.

Demand decoding: This is a technology-plus-society question. For Topic 14, use it only to sharpen the link between technique, communication, fortification and administrative reach.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Group the answer into architecture, irrigation-craft and war-communication fields, then borrow Sur examples only in the concluding transfer line on routes, forts and organised state movement.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks by preserving the original Sultanate scope while still extracting a disciplined lesson for Sher Shah's circulation-and-control system.

How to improve/strengthen: End with one direct contrast: technology can assist state capacity, but it never replaces political organisation, revenue support and disciplined command.

Original solved Mains questions

Exactly six original Mains models are retained below: **2 x 10 marks**, **2 x 15 marks**, **2 x 20 marks**.

Original Mains 1 - Why does Sher Shah's five-year reign hold a disproportionately large place in medieval Indian history? (10 marks; 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Sher Shah's brief reign mattered because it joined conquest to a visibly working administrative programme.

Named evidence and analysis. The most convincing evidence is the cluster of measures remembered together: measured revenue demand, patta-qabuliyat, a standard silver rupiya, safer long-distance roads, sarais used for relay movement, and stern action against robbers and rebellious zamindars. These measures did not operate in isolation. Revenue made payment possible; coinage aided exchange; roads and sarais moved troops, merchants and intelligence; coercive order kept the whole network usable.

Qualification. The reputation should still be qualified. Sarwani wrote later and admired Sher Shah, regional implementation was uneven, and a five-year reign cannot prove universal routine across every district. Nor did Sher Shah invent every measure from nothing.

Conclusion. His historical weight comes from practical systematisation under short time pressure, not from mythical perfection.

Demand decoding: The directive asks for proportion and explanation together. You must show why the reign seems 'large' without letting admiration erase the limits of short duration and source idealisation.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Begin with one sentence on short reign versus lasting reputation, deploy three concrete evidence clusters - revenue, circulation and coercive order - and close with a clear qualification rather than an uncritical tribute.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it explains importance through interlocking institutions instead of listing reforms like disconnected facts.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one named site such as Sasaram, Rohtas or the Indus-Sonargaon road to make the administrative claim spatially grounded.

Original Mains 2 - Explain the administrative importance and the limit of patta-qabuliyat under Sher Shah. (10 marks; 150 words)

Model solution

Claim. Patta-qabuliyat mattered because it made the state's demand more explicit, but it did not produce a direct modern peasant-state settlement.

Named evidence and analysis. The patta recorded the assessed holding, crop or area basis and demand; qabuliyat marked acceptance by the cultivator. In combination with measurement and rai schedules, this strengthened fiscal legibility. A ruler could compare dues, restrain arbitrary local exaction in principle and organise collection more rationally.

Qualification. The limit is equally important. Zamindars, muqaddams, qanungos and other local agents remained central. The famous one-third share is a norm, not proof of identical practice everywhere, and the advanced owner explicitly warns through the Multan exception against imagining universal application.

Conclusion. Patta-qabuliyat improved record-based assessment, but within a mediated agrarian regime still marked by uneven enforcement and coercive collection.

Demand decoding: The question is double-edged: importance alone is incomplete, and criticism alone is also incomplete. Keep both the administrative gain and the structural limit equally visible.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Use a two-part answer - what patta-qabuliyat clarified, then what it did not transform - and anchor each part with one named institutional detail.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: The answer earns marks by refusing the common shortcut that translates written assessment into ryotwari or agrarian equality.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the phrases 'rai' and 'Multan exception' if space permits; they show control over both mechanism and limit.

Original Mains 3 - Discuss how roads, sarais and customs reform turned circulation into state capacity under Sher Shah. (15 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Sher Shah's roads, sarais and customs measures mattered not merely for transport but for the political management of movement.

Evidence and analysis. The basic owner ties Sher Shah to the repaired east-west route from the Indus to Sonargaon and to branch roads from Agra toward Rajasthan and from Lahore to Multan; the advanced owner adds the Agra-Burhanpur line. These corridors mattered because armies, tax collections, merchants and royal orders used the same channels. Sarais at intervals supplied lodging, resting animals, market exchange and security. Their use as dak stages turned physical movement into an information system. Customs simplification, associated with dues at controlled entry and sale points rather than repeated petty levies, reduced some friction in long-distance trade and made collection more legible.

The larger significance is institutional. Revenue and money become more effective when goods and officers can move safely; military reaction becomes faster when routes and relay points are reliable; intelligence becomes sharper when messages have fixed stopping places. In that sense circulation itself became a governing resource.

Qualification. The roads were largely repaired or improved older corridors, not wholly invented lines. Sarai spacing and perfection of implementation must not be overstated, and trade support remained tied to surveillance and extraction.

Conclusion. Sher Shah converted communication infrastructure into administrative reach by binding mobility to information and control.

Demand decoding: The directive wants a process answer. Do not stop at naming roads; show how route, sarai and customs policy together changed what the state could actually do.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Organise the answer as corridor -> node -> collection logic -> state effect, then end with one sentence on limit so the infrastructure claim stays historically disciplined.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it turns infrastructure into an argument about governance, not a sightseeing note on famous roads.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the phrase 'dak stage' explicitly; it proves that you understand sarais as communication nodes as well as shelters.

Original Mains 4 - Assess Sher Shah's military and frontier policy with reference to dagh, chehra and fort strategy. (15 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Sher Shah's military strength lay in verification and strategic position rather than in battlefield heroics alone.

Evidence and analysis. The core military-control devices associated with him are dagh for horse branding and chehra for descriptive identification of soldiers. These practices checked fraud in cavalry service and connected payment with inspection. Yet the advanced owner warns that they had Sultanate precedents, so Sher Shah's contribution is best written as disciplined adaptation rather than invention. Fort strategy completes the picture. Chunar mattered as an eastern route-fort, while Rohtas in the north-west was tied to control over the Gakhhars and to guarding against a Mughal return. Rohtasgarh in Bihar must be kept distinct. The army also operated through cavalry, infantry, elephants, artillery and different logistics in Bengal river zones, Punjab routes and Rajasthan campaigning.

The analysis is that control of soldiers, horses and fort lines made frontier rule more durable than a mere victory list could suggest. The army was embedded in routes, supplies and strongpoints.

Qualification. Our evidence preserves the ideal of discipline more fully than full audited rosters, and later Mughal organisation differed in scale and framework.

Conclusion. Sher Shah's frontier policy was effective because inspection and fort geography reinforced one another.

Demand decoding: This is an assessment question, so combine evaluation with evidence. Explain what dagh, chehra and forts achieved before moving to the limit.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Write in three moves - control devices, fort geography, then frontier consequence - and use one contrast sentence to separate precedent from Sur adaptation.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: The answer earns marks because it makes military administration concrete through identifiable mechanisms and places.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the Kalinjar reference if space remains; it reminds the examiner that siege warfare strengthened the state yet also carried risk.

Original Mains 5 - Critically examine the structure of Sur administration from the king to the village level. (20 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Sur administration under Sher Shah was a centralising but mediated monarchy that reached the countryside more effectively without becoming a modern direct bureaucracy.

From the centre downward. At the apex stood a forceful ruler who supervised finance, military affairs, chancery and justice-religious functions through Sultanate-derived portfolios. This central court mattered because revenue demand, coinage, roads, army inspection and punitive authority had to be coordinated from above.

Territorial layering. Beneath the centre, sarkars or shiqs and parganas formed the operational chain. Administrative descriptions associate them with military-police supervision, revenue assessment, record-keeping, local treasuries and judicial work. At the village level, cultivators, muqaddams, patwaris, panchayats and zamindars remained indispensable. That is the key structural truth of the topic: the state penetrated the countryside through layered mediation, not by replacing local society.

Critical evaluation. This structure gave Sher Shah notable advantages. Revenue could be stated more clearly; orders could travel more securely; local disorder could be punished more quickly. Yet its limits were real. Much description survives through later chronicle reconstruction; office functions were unlikely to be identical in every district; and personal supervision by the ruler remained unusually important. The system's later succession fragility underlines that dependence.

Qualification and conclusion. Sur administration therefore deserves praise as a coordinated short-reign system, but not description as either a finished Akbarian suba order or a direct modern district state.

Demand decoding: The question requires structural explanation plus criticism. A bare list of offices will not score unless you show how the chain worked and where it remained dependent on mediation and personal rule.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Move top-down - ruler, sarkar, pargana, village - and place one evaluative sentence after each level so structure and criticism advance together.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it answers the exact phrase 'from the king to the village level' instead of drifting into generic praise of reforms.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one named local intermediary such as muqaddam or qanungo and one caution about Akbar's subas to sharpen both texture and historical boundary.

Original Mains 6 - How far was Sher Shah a precursor of Akbar? Give a qualified answer. (20 marks; 250 words)

Model solution

Claim. Sher Shah was a precursor of Akbar in a real but limited sense: he demonstrated workable lines of revenue, circulation, coinage and military control that the later Mughals adapted rather than copied.

Areas of continuity. The most obvious links lie in revenue measurement, rai-type rate logic, patta-style record consciousness, road and sarai management, standard coinage, and the remembered use of dagh-chehra. These measures made state demand, payment and movement more legible. That achievement helps explain why later historians repeatedly connect Sher Shah with later Mughal effectiveness.

Why the precursor label must be qualified. First, many of these elements had Sultanate precedents; Sher Shah did not invent them all. Second, Akbar's order operated on a wider territorial scale, with subas, mansabdari integration and a more durable documentary regime. Third, the Sur state's own rapid fragmentation after Islam Shah shows that Sher Shah had not already solved the succession and coalition problems that a long-lasting empire had to solve.

Judgement. The right verdict is selective continuity. Sher Shah proved that a north-Indian monarchy could coordinate revenue, mobility and enforcement more tightly than before. Akbar's greatness lay in stabilising and enlarging some of these lines under a broader imperial settlement.

Conclusion. Precursor is therefore a useful analytical word only when paired with adaptation, precedent and limit.

Demand decoding: The phrase 'how far' requires a graded answer. You must identify genuine continuity and then state clearly where the label breaks down.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Use a two-column mental structure - continuity on one side, limits on the other - and reserve the conclusion for a measured verdict rather than an all-or-nothing claim.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it keeps three levels distinct: Sultanate precedent, Sur systematisation and Akbarian expansion.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one comparison pair such as patta-qabuliyat versus later zabt or dagh-chehra versus mansabdari controls to make the graded verdict more concrete.